feet 4 inches in diameter, wrought iron tyres volute springs, originally costing about ₹7,000 each.

₹1 PER SNAKE TO CLEAR PATH FOR THE MATHERAN HILL RAILWAY

The construction of the Matheran Hill Railway near Mumbai has several interesting anecdotes associated with it. One of them is how the businessman who was building his dream railway offered incentives to overcome workers' superstitions and get the line built faster.

For starters, the Matheran Hill Railway, a tentative UNESCO (United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization) World Heritage Site in the category of Mountain Railways of India, [80] is a 2-foot gauge, 21-mile stretch of railway that winds up from Neral at the base (connected to the mainline station) through zigzags, tunnels and deep cuttings, taking the train uphill in about two hours. It was built by an ambitious businessman, Abdul Hussain Adamjee Peerbhoy, financed by his father Sir Adamjee Peerbhoy, at a cost of ₹16 lakh (US$ 24,000) between 1901 and 1907 .

The hill station of Matheran had always been popular as a vacation spot, and Sir Peerbhoy had been a regular visitor. He thought of a railway, and building it became the passion of his life. Procuring all necessary government permissions, his plans materialized by 1900 and construction began in 1904. It was a challenging task, right from the digging of the mountain to the building of the line. The curves and zigzags demanded special locomotives and technology. He overcame it all, one by one. Excerpts from the construction diary of the Peerbhoy family:

> From 1900, Abdul Hussain Adamjee Peerbhoy stayed with his family at Neral, to make his dream come true. For the next few years, he spent his days and nights in the jungles on the hills. On 20 June 1904, the government declared Notification No. 25 signed by secretary G.A. Anderson stating that the total responsibility of the Matheran Mountain Railway will be upon Abdul Hussain Adamjee Peerbhoy. Thereafter, by Notification No. 34 dated 28 July 1904, Abdul Hussain Adamjee Peerbhoy was authorized to construct and maintain a line of light railway.
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> When the work on the line started with the support of an Indian engineer (popular as Rao Saheb), a man of mild nature with pleasing manners, there were numerous issues. One of the biggest challenges was that when the rocks on the hillside were blasted for construction, hundreds of snakes slithered out of their age-old homes, and workmen could not kill them due to superstitions. It was only when an offer of ₹1 per snake as an incentive was announced that the workers overcame superstition. Abdul Hussain Adamjee Peerbhoy